Chapter 1 · Story

Maya arrives late. The room has already decided why.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

Leo is assigning the opening shift. What is his most informative next move?

A Ask Maya about today and check her availability.

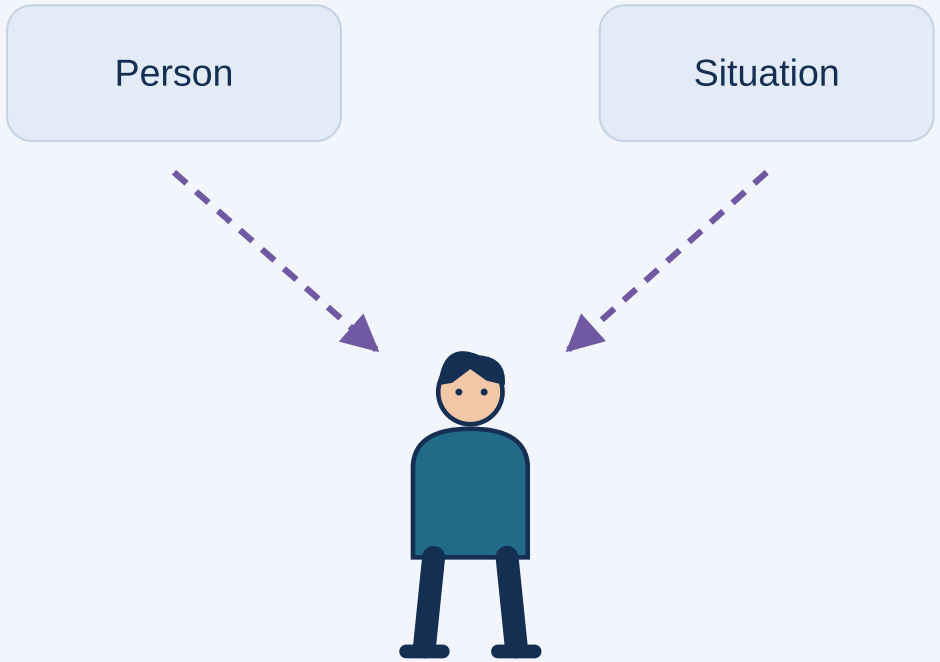
B Use today’s lateness as the main sign of reliability.

C Ignore today and assume she will arrive on time.

Suggested answer: A. Asking Maya about the delay lets Leo investigate the obstacle and plan the shift without ignoring the lateness.

Behavior has more than one author.

- **Person**: tendencies, goals, beliefs, skills
- **Disposition**: a usual tendency, such as patience
- **Situation**: demands, people, available choices
- **Interaction**: pressure can strain usual patience

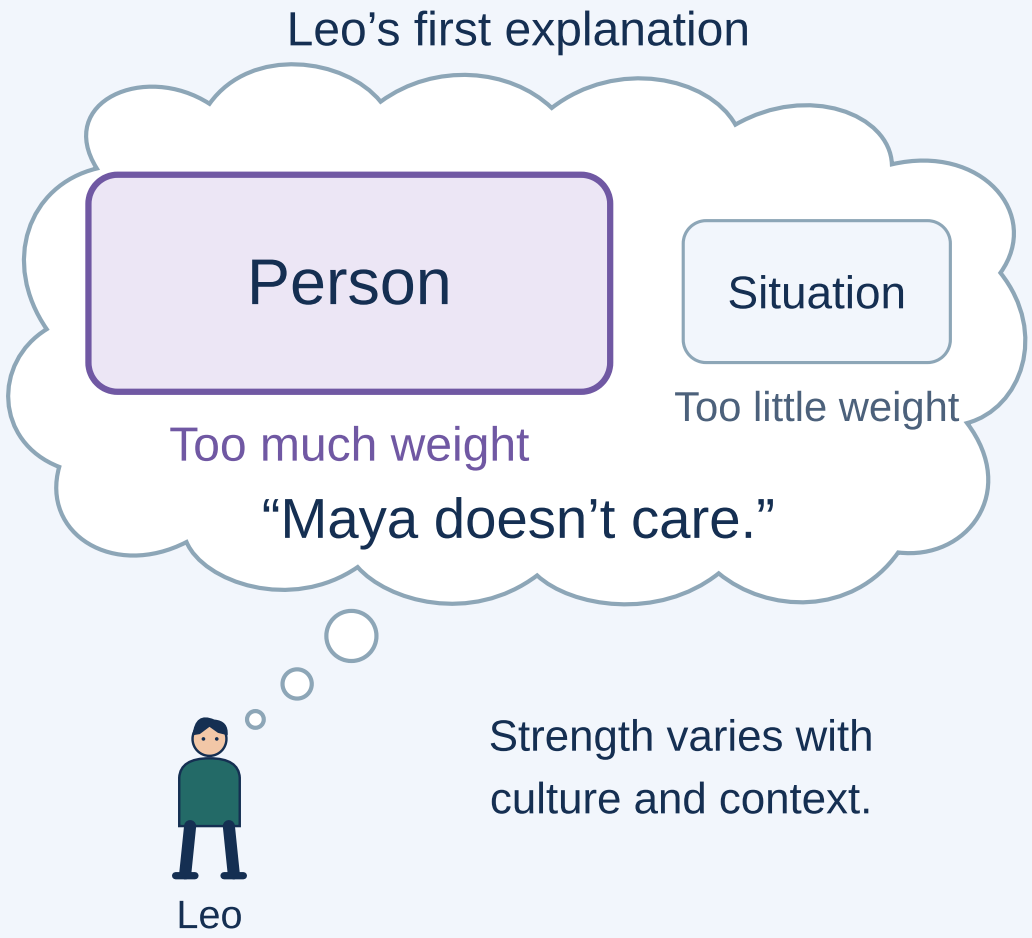


Behavior emerges in context.

Person and situation both contribute to behavior.

Observation is not explanation.

- **Observation**: Maya arrived after the start.
- **Attribution**: Leo explains it as not caring.
- **Fundamental attribution error**: too much weight on the person, too little on the situation.
- **Check**: compare behavior across situations.

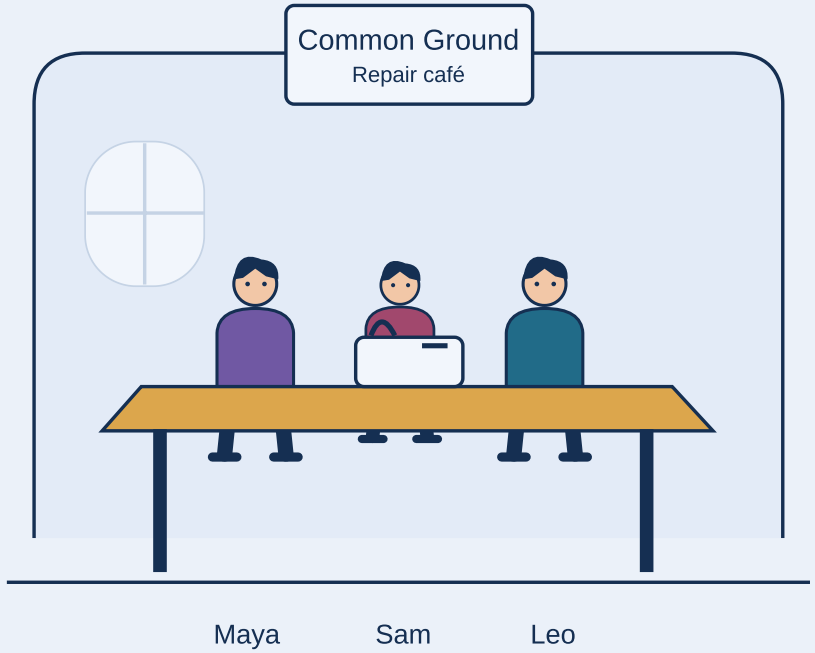


Strength varies with culture and context.

The imbalance is in Leo’s explanation.

What can we really conclude?

An attribution is an explanation of what caused an action. Saying “Maya arrived late” records an observation. Saying “Maya arrived late because she doesn’t care” adds an attribution about her priorities. Attribution research describes patterns in how people explain behavior. It does not establish that personal qualities never matter. Repeated behavior across varied settings is more informative than one episode. Researchers also examine actor–observer differences: differences between how we explain our own actions and other people’s actions. We might explain our own lateness through a delayed bus, but someone else’s through poor planning. Whether that pattern appears depends on the judgment and study design. A bias label alone cannot reveal what is happening in someone’s mind.



Try the idea somewhere new.

A volunteer misses shifts only when the bus service is suspended. What should you test?

A Whether personality alone predicts attendance.

B Whether another travel plan improves attendance.

C Whether the missed shifts can be deleted.

Suggested answer: B. Trying another travel plan tests the suspected barrier while keeping the attendance expectation clear.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Explain observation versus attribution.

> What would strengthen a personal explanation?

1. An observation records an action. An attribution proposes a cause for that action.

2. An explanation based on a personal tendency becomes more credible when the behavior recurs across varied circumstances and plausible alternatives have been examined.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Choose a mildly frustrating encounter. Write the action, your first interpretation, two alternatives, and one respectful question that could clarify it.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 2 · Story

A brighter poster. More visitors. A cause?

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



The poster that “worked” · c02s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

Which statement fits Leo’s evidence?

A The poster caused the increase.

B The poster had no effect.

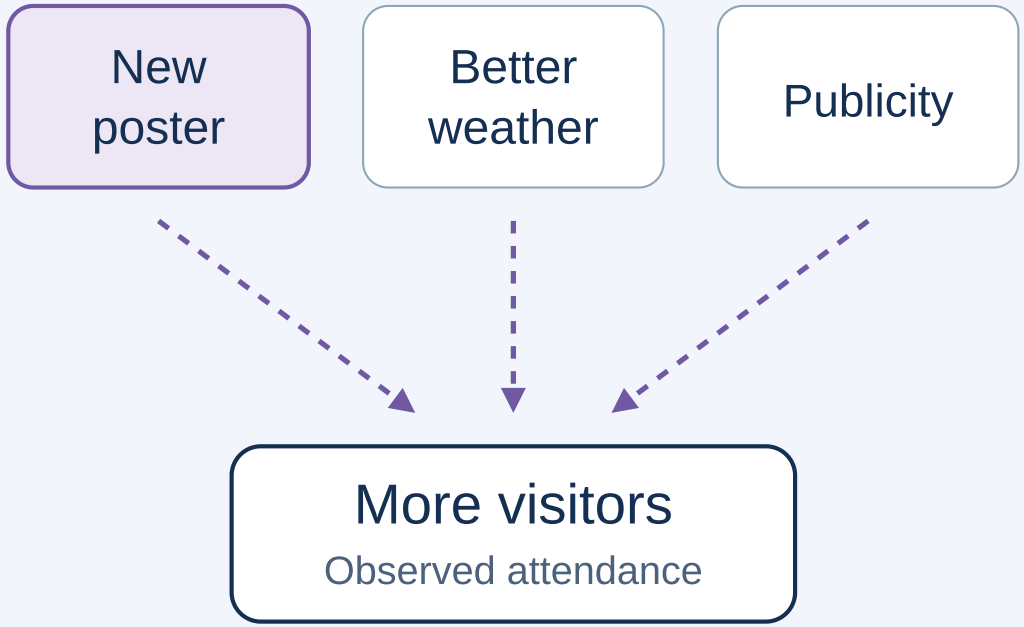
C Attendance rose; several causes remain possible.

Suggested answer: C. Saying that attendance rose preserves the observation. Leaving the cause open reflects the limits of the comparison.

Comparison makes a claim testable.

- **Correlation**: things vary together.
- **Confound**: another factor could explain the pattern.
- **Random assignment**: allocate conditions by chance.
- **Random sampling**: select people from a population by chance.

Several changes, one outcome



Dashed paths: possible explanations

A fair comparison separates explanations.

Several changes can fit the same before-and-after pattern.

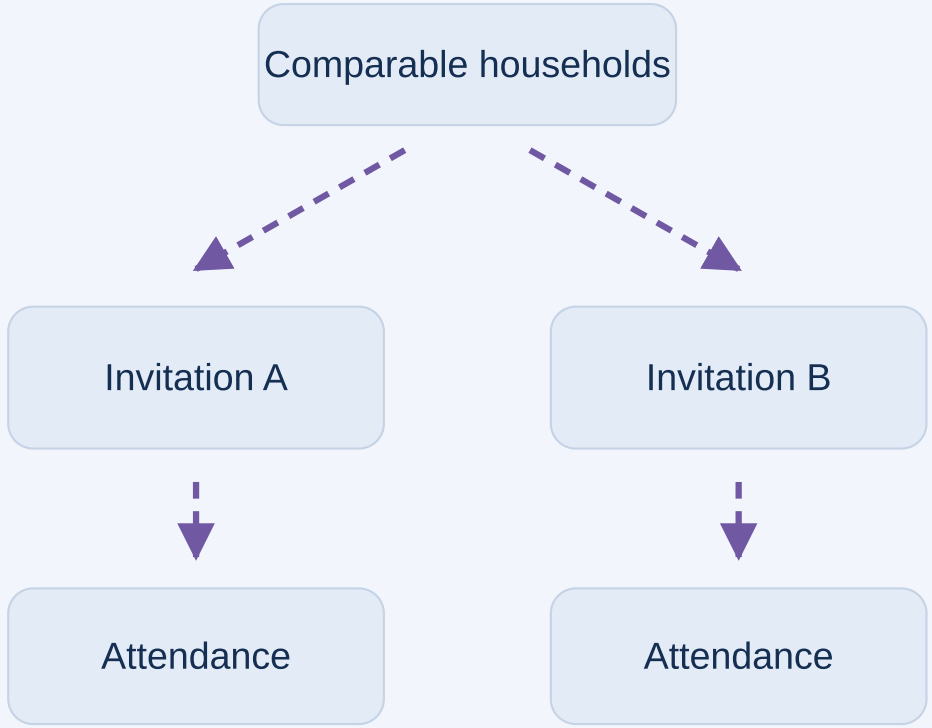
Ask how much—and how uncertain.

Size: 12% versus 15% is a difference of three percentage points.

Uncertainty: another sample may give a different estimate.

Statistical significance: judged against a model, often assuming no group difference.

Significance does not establish practical importance; nonsignificance does not prove zero effect.

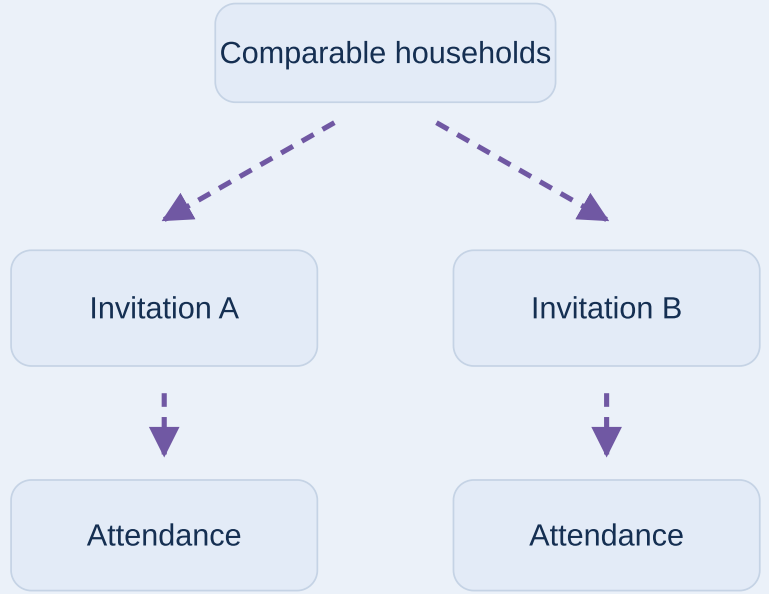


Allocate by chance. Compare like with like.

Random assignment supports a fairer comparison.

What can we really conclude?

Replication repeats a test to examine how dependable a finding is. Independent tests help us learn whether a result holds up elsewhere. Preregistration records the planned methods and analysis before results are known. That advance record reduces some opportunities for selective reporting. Preregistration cannot rescue a poor design. With a sound design, a larger sample can narrow the uncertainty around an estimate. More observations cannot fix a systematically unfair comparison. Sharing the study's methods and materials lets others inspect how it was done. A memorable study is a starting point for evaluation, rather than a final verdict.



Allocate by chance. Compare like with like.

Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Which invitation comparison is strongest?

A Design A in winter; design B in summer.

B Randomize designs for one event; define attendance in advance.

C Design A for existing fans; design B for newcomers.

Suggested answer: B. Randomizing invitations for one event improves the comparison. Also check whether households share invitations.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> How does random assignment differ from random sampling?

> Why is before-and-after evidence insufficient?

1. Random assignment allocates people to conditions. Random sampling selects people from a population.

2. Other conditions can change over time and produce the same before-and-after pattern.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Find an everyday causal claim. Name its outcome, one competing explanation, and a feasible comparison. State whose behavior the result would represent.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 3 · Story

One broken toaster becomes “they always break.”

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



The story that comes to mind · c03s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

What most improves the estimate of repeat failures?

A A detailed account of the worst failure.

B Failures divided by comparable completed repairs.

C A vote on whose impression feels realistic.

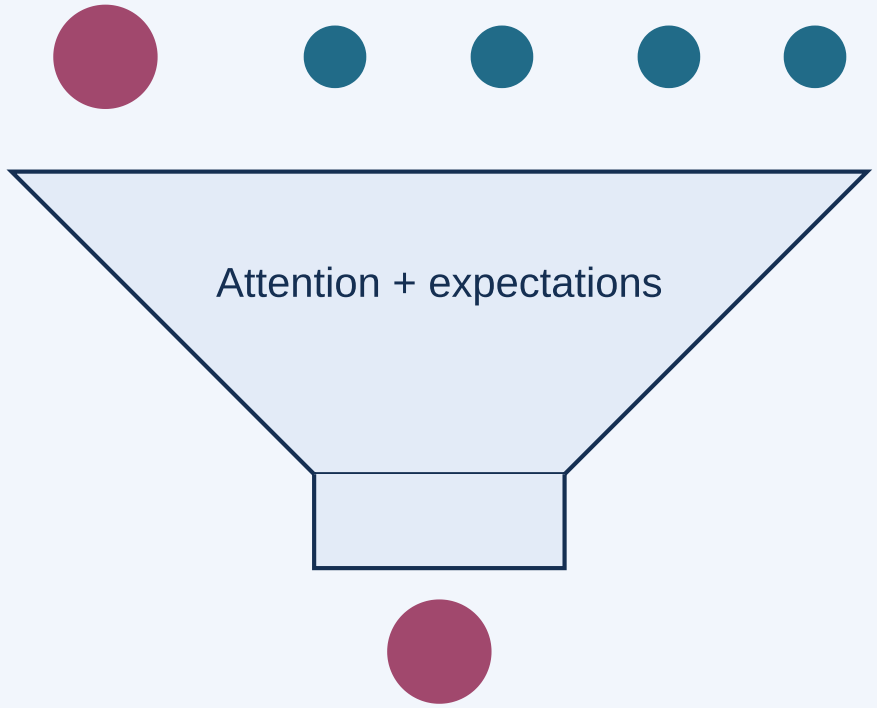
Suggested answer: B. The total of comparable repairs provides the denominator for a failure rate. Consistent follow-up still matters.

Memorable is not the same as common.

> **Availability heuristic**: easy-to-recall examples shape judgment.

> **Base rate**: how common is it among comparable cases?

> **Denominator**: total comparable repairs, including successes.

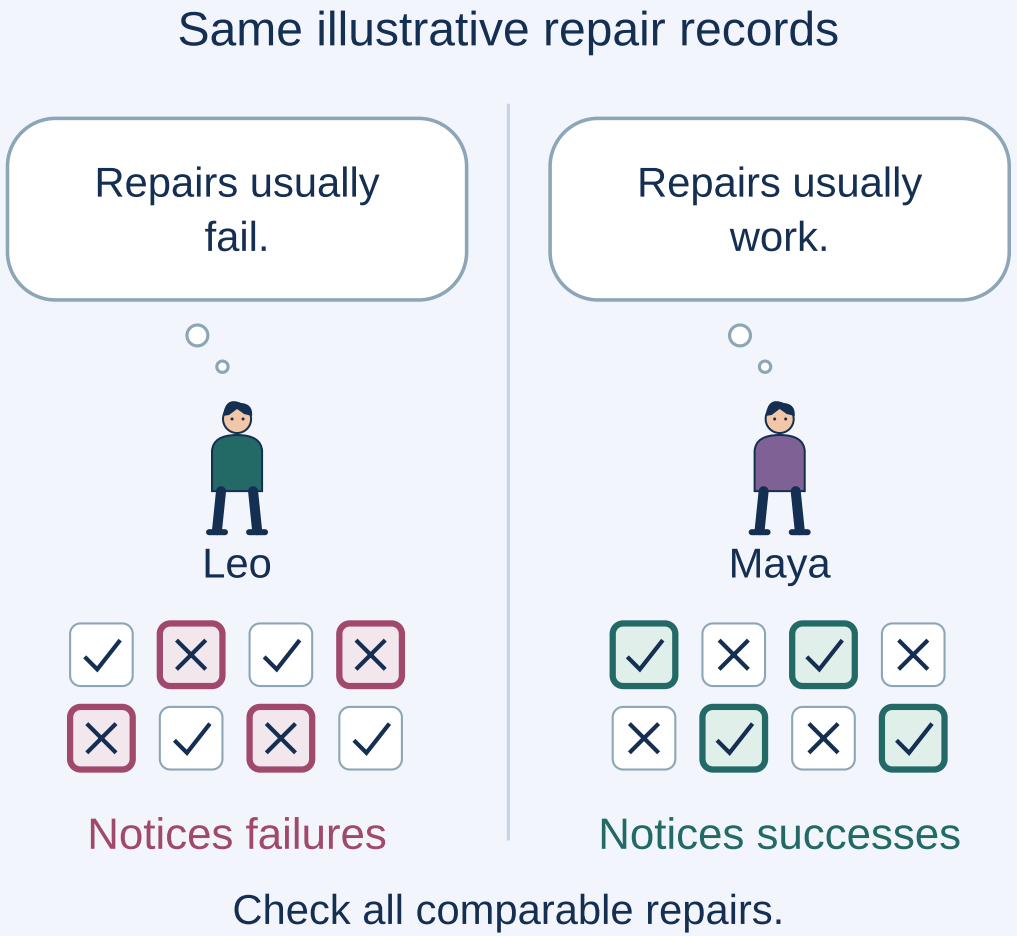


What reaches us is a selected sample.

Attention and expectations select the evidence we notice.

Beliefs can filter their own evidence.

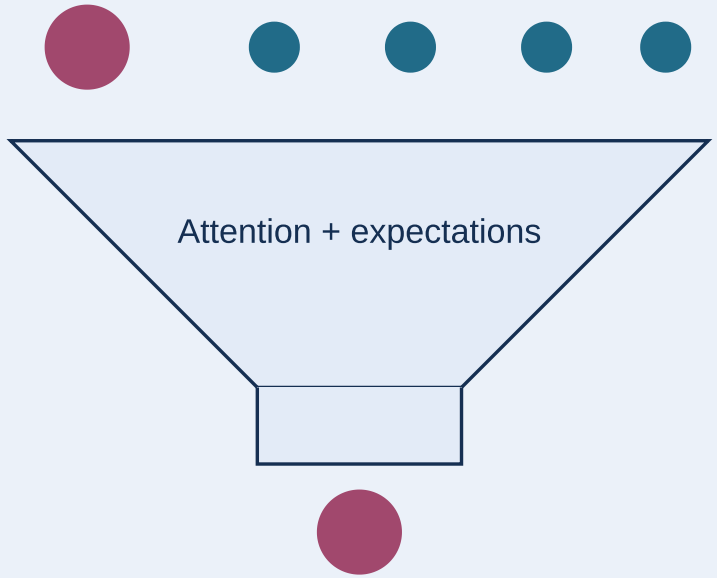
- **Confirmation bias**: seeking or interpreting evidence to fit an existing belief.
- **Motivated reasoning**: what we want to be true influences our reasoning.
- **Check**: what evidence could change your mind?



Expectations can change which evidence gets attention.

What can we really conclude?

A bias name cannot establish why a particular person reached a particular judgment. Compare the judgment with relevant data before deciding what went wrong. For example, a memorable set of cases might distort a judgment through availability. Or those cases might accurately reflect an expert’s experience. A representative record helps distinguish those possibilities. Corrective strategies are useful aids. They do not make anyone immune to error. Experts also need feedback and procedures that allow expectations to be challenged.



What reaches us is a selected sample.

Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Leo thinks evening sessions fail. Which question best challenges his belief?

A Which evenings went badly?

B Who agrees that evenings are a poor idea?

C What outcomes would make us conclude evenings work?

Suggested answer: C. Naming outcomes that would count as success gives Leo’s belief a chance to be wrong.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Why does a vivid case need a denominator?

> When can an availability shortcut be useful?

1. The denominator is the total of comparable cases. Four failed repairs mean something different among forty repairs than among four hundred. Consistent follow-up is needed to estimate the failure rate.

2. An availability shortcut can help when the examples that come to mind reliably represent the relevant events.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Keep a small record of one everyday prediction for a week. Include successes and failures. Avoid collecting private information about others. Compare the whole record with your first impression.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 4 · Story

“I chose it” quietly becomes “it must be right.”

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

What makes honest revision easier?

A Review failures and compare options afresh.

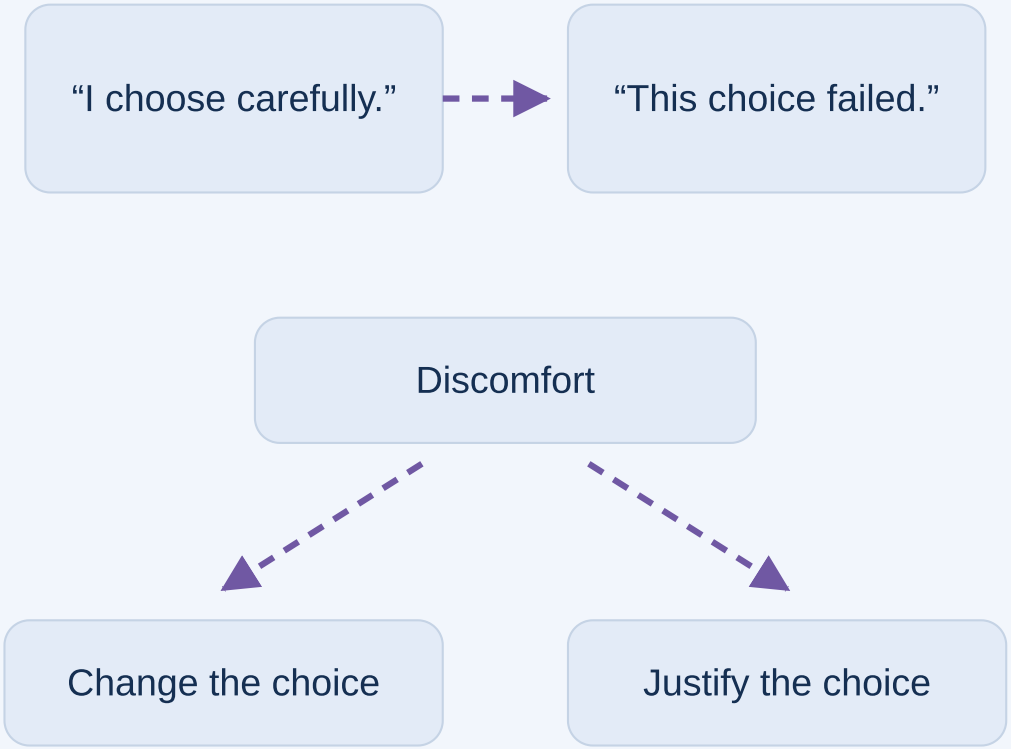
B Remind Maya that a competent coordinator would know better.

C Keep the system until the investment feels worthwhile.

Suggested answer: A. Reviewing failures and comparing options turns attention toward outcomes and the next decision.

Inconsistency can feel uncomfortable.

- **Cognitive dissonance**: inconsistency between beliefs or actions can feel uncomfortable.
- **Cognitions**: beliefs and knowledge about our actions.
- “I choose reliable tools” clashes with a system that loses bookings.
- Reduce discomfort by revising a belief or action, or adding a justification.



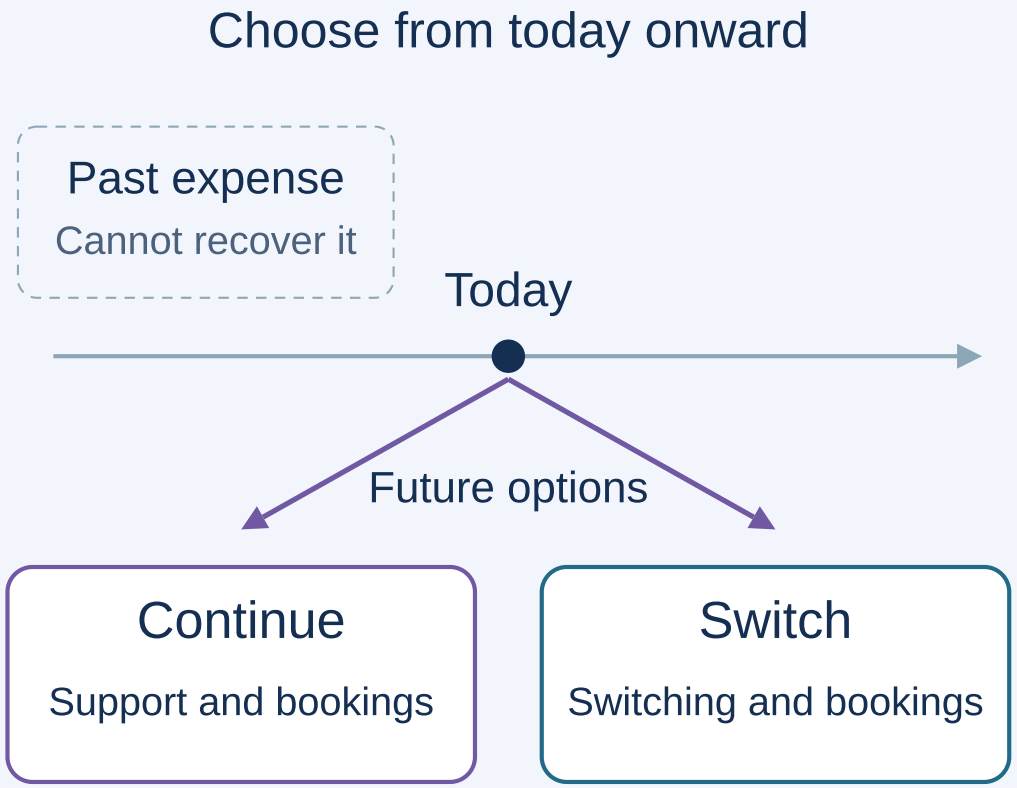
Inconsistency can lead to revision or justification.

Give the future a fresh vote.

> **Sunk cost**: money, time, or effort that cannot be recovered.

> **Sunk cost effect**: letting that past expense drive the next choice.

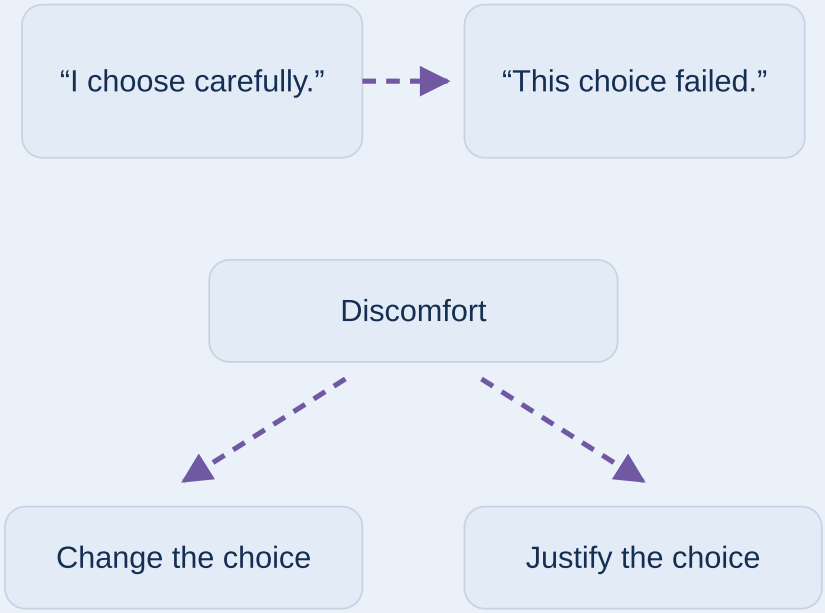
> Compare future benefits and costs, including switching and usable skills.



Past spending is unrecoverable; compare future consequences.

What can we really conclude?

Evidence for specific cognitive dissonance demonstrations is uneven. In 2024, researchers repeated one procedure across multiple laboratories. Participants were asked to argue for a position they did not hold, with more or less choice about doing so. This is called an induced-compliance procedure. The study tested whether the amount of choice affected later attitudes. Its primary analysis did not support the predicted difference between the higher-choice and lower-choice groups. That result challenges the particular procedure tested. It does not settle every version of cognitive dissonance theory. Distinguish the broad explanation of discomfort and justification from the evidence for a particular prediction. The linked Vaidis and colleagues study provides the details.



Try the idea somewhere new.

Switching costs £100; keeping the tool costs £300 in future support. Benefits are equal. What matters?

A The large fee already paid.

B The lower avoidable future cost of switching.

C Only the emotional discomfort of switching.

Suggested answer: B. Under the stated assumptions, switching costs one hundred pounds and keeping the tool costs three hundred. Real choices also compare risks.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Name two ways to reduce dissonance.

> When can a past investment still matter?

1. People may reduce dissonance by changing a behavior or belief, or by adding a justification. Context affects the response.

2. A past investment matters when it changes future consequences, such as switching costs or usable skills.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Revisit a small commitment you can change. List the future benefits and avoidable costs of continuing or stopping. Write a sentence that permits correction without attacking your character.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 5 · Story

Everyone says yes. Has everyone agreed?

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



The quiet vote · c05s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

What could reveal concerns before discussion?

A Have the chair announce the preferred answer.

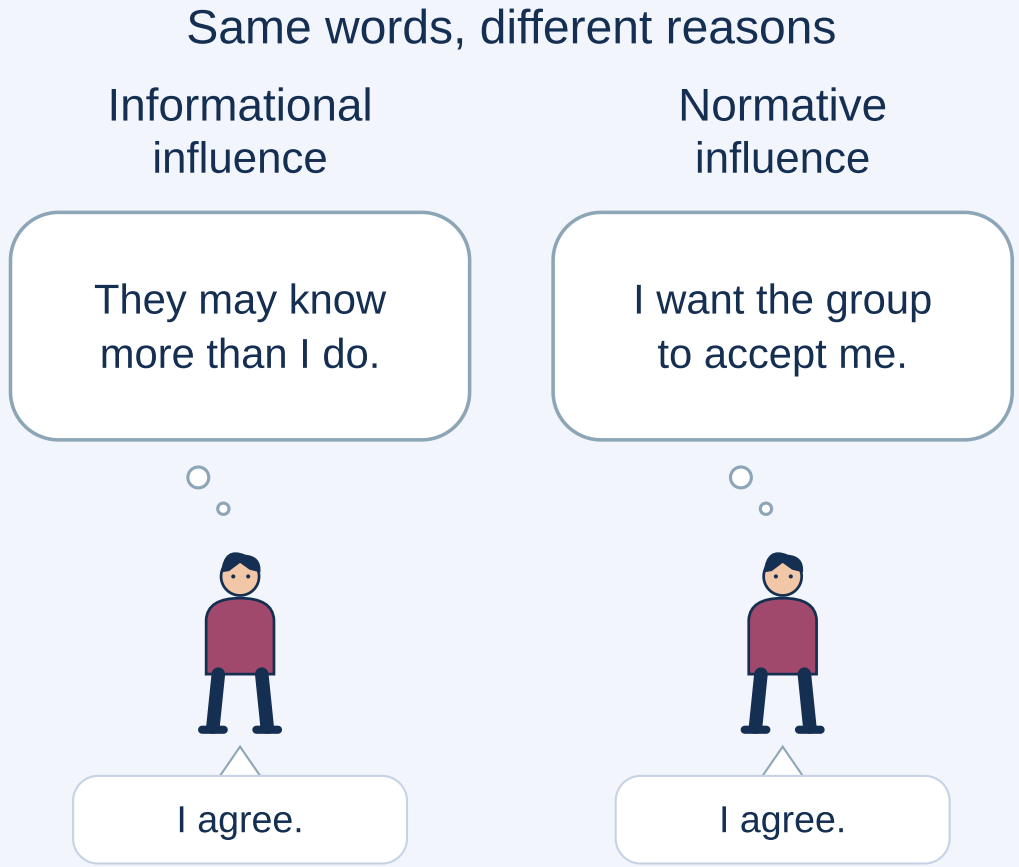
B Collect independent written judgments first.

C Ask only experienced members to speak.

Suggested answer: B. Independent written judgments let people record a view before seeing which answer has public support.

Two reasons to follow a group.

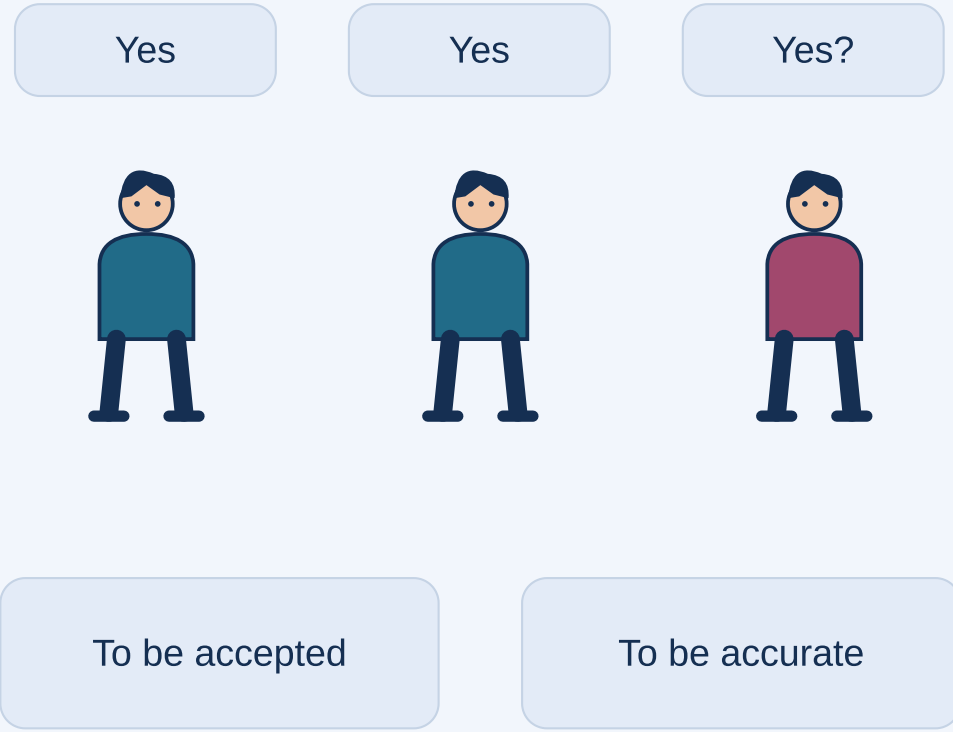
- **Informational influence**: they may know better.
- **Normative influence**: I want acceptance.
- Public agreement can differ from private belief.



The same public agreement can reflect different private reasons.

Authority changes the pressure.

- **Compliance**: responding to a request.
- **Obedience**: responding to an authority’s order.
- Make stopping and questioning possible.

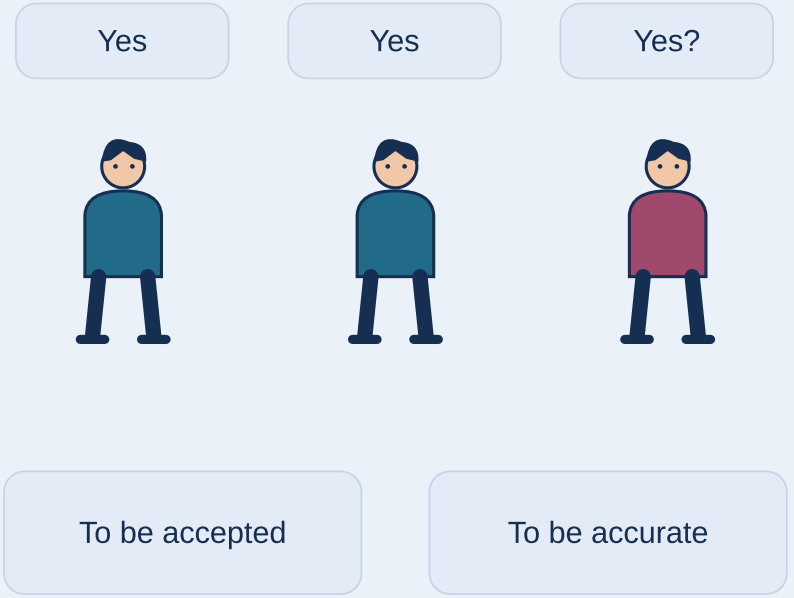


The same answer can have different motives.

Public agreement can reflect acceptance or information.

What can we really conclude?

In Asch’s line-judgment studies, participants compared line lengths after hearing a group give incorrect answers. The studies examined when people would follow a majority despite the visible evidence. In Milgram’s studies, an experimenter urged participants to continue a task they believed delivered electric shocks to another person. The studies examined responses to apparent authority in a highly structured setting. Both sets of studies raise questions about methods, ethics, and how widely their findings apply. Their results concern particular conditions of influence; they are not universal obedience rates. Some participants resisted, and responses varied with the conditions. Harmful conduct is not inevitable.



The same answer can have different motives.

Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

The chair requests bypassing a required check. Which process helps?

A Let the first confident person decide.

B Allow anonymous complaints afterward.

C Pause and use an agreed safety escalation route.

Suggested answer: C. An agreed stop-and-escalation route makes questioning possible while the safety decision still matters.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Distinguish normative and informational influence.

> Why can public agreement overstate private agreement?

1. Normative influence concerns acceptance. Informational influence treats other people’s responses as evidence.

2. Public agreement can hide private doubt when people copy early answers, suppress concerns, or assume that others have checked.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

For an agreed, low-stakes group choice, have everyone write a view before discussion. Compare the range of initial reasons with what a show of hands might have revealed.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 6 · Story

Two invitations. Different reasons to care.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



The invitation · c06s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

A potential volunteer worries about the time commitment. What information would help most?

A A second celebrity endorsement.

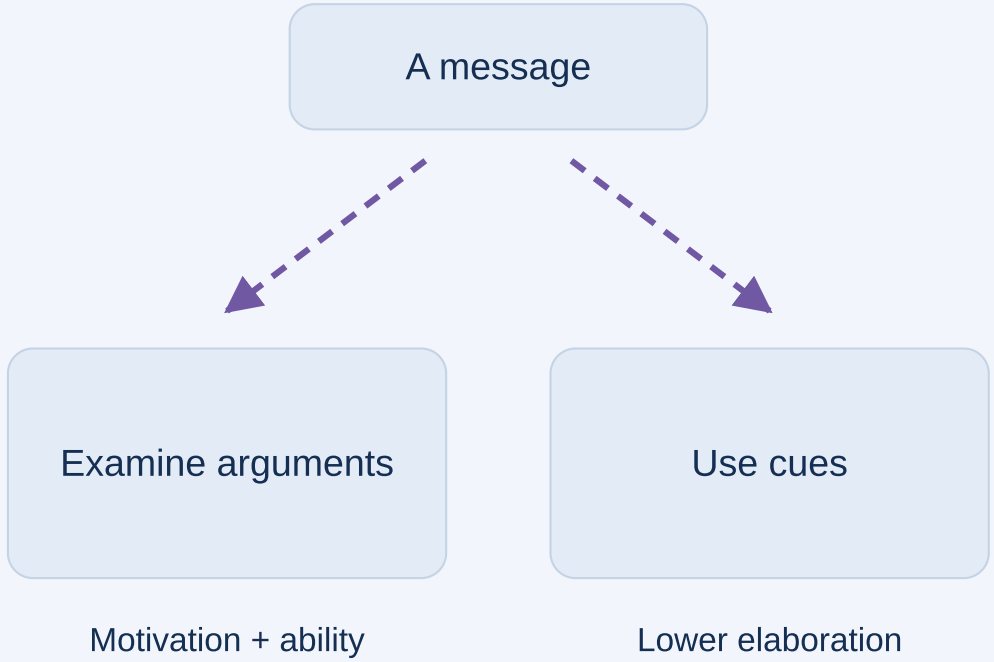
B Shift length, support, and an optional trial.

C A stronger claim that this is unmissable.

Suggested answer: B. Shift length, support, and an optional trial give the volunteer relevant information about the commitment.

Attention and evaluation are different jobs.

- **Attitude**: an evaluation of something.
- **Elaboration likelihood model**: motivation and ability shape careful thinking.
- **Central processing**: examine relevant arguments.
- **Peripheral processing**: give more weight to cues such as familiarity.

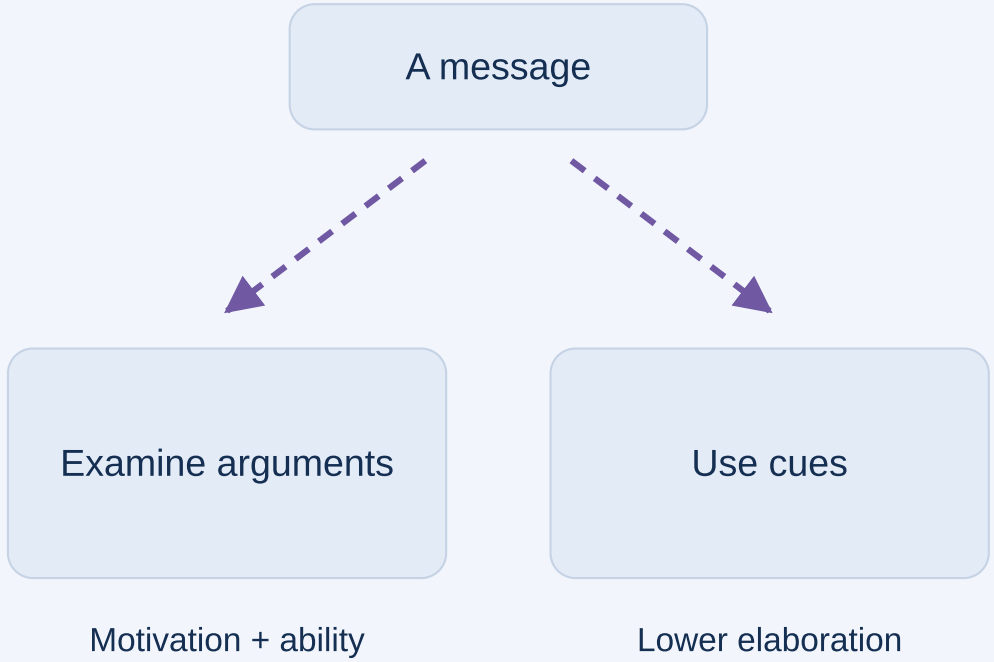


Processing changes with the decision.

Argument evaluation and cue use vary with motivation and ability.

A norm must be true to be useful.

- **Descriptive norm**: what people do.
- **Injunctive norm**: what people approve.
- A clear request needs an easy next step.

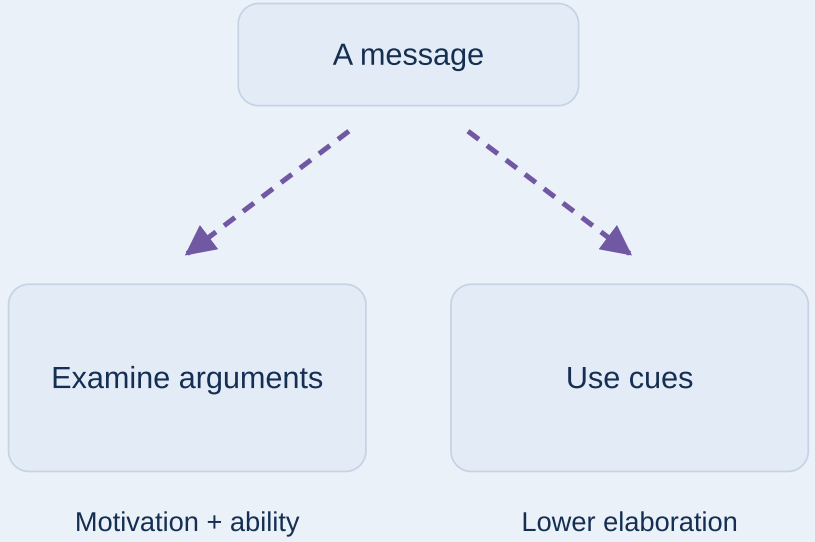


Processing changes with the decision.

Argument evaluation and cue use vary with motivation and ability.

What can we really conclude?

Persuasion depends on the audience, topic, source, and outcome being measured. A changed survey answer is not the same outcome as sustained behavior change. Treat a revised invitation as a hypothesis to test. An increase in clicks does not establish that people understood the commitment or will continue volunteering. Compare comprehension, informed sign-ups, and retention. Ask whether people understood the effort involved and felt able to decline. Those measures are closer to the decision the café needs to support.



Processing changes with the decision.

Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Few residents currently volunteer. Which invitation is defensible?

A “Everyone here already volunteers.”

B “Hardly anyone helps—don’t be like them.”

C “Try a supported two-hour shift; here is what it involves.”

Suggested answer: C. A supported two-hour trial is a concrete, checkable request. Its effect on informed participation still needs evaluation.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> What makes central processing more likely?

> Distinguish descriptive and injunctive norms.

1. Central processing is more likely when someone is motivated and has the ability, attention, and information to examine the arguments.

2. Descriptive norms concern what people do. Injunctive norms concern approval.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Rewrite a low-stakes invitation. State the decision, relevant reason, effort required, and next step. Remove social-proof claims you cannot substantiate.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 7 · Story

Two teams stop sharing a table.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



When “we” takes over · c07s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

The shared checklist is unfinished. What is a useful first change?

A Agree on owners, deadlines, and needed support.

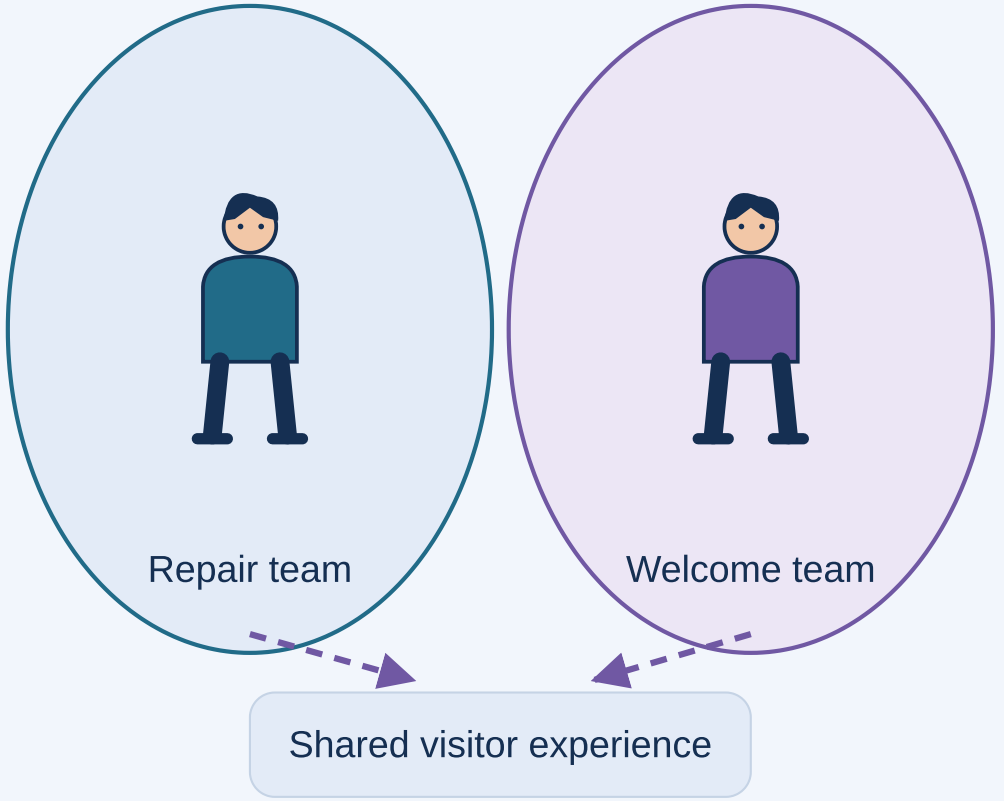
B Tell everyone their commitment is disappointing.

C Copy more people onto every task.

Suggested answer: A. Agreed owners, deadlines, and support make responsibility clearer and help people coordinate the work.

Identity changes the boundary of “us.”

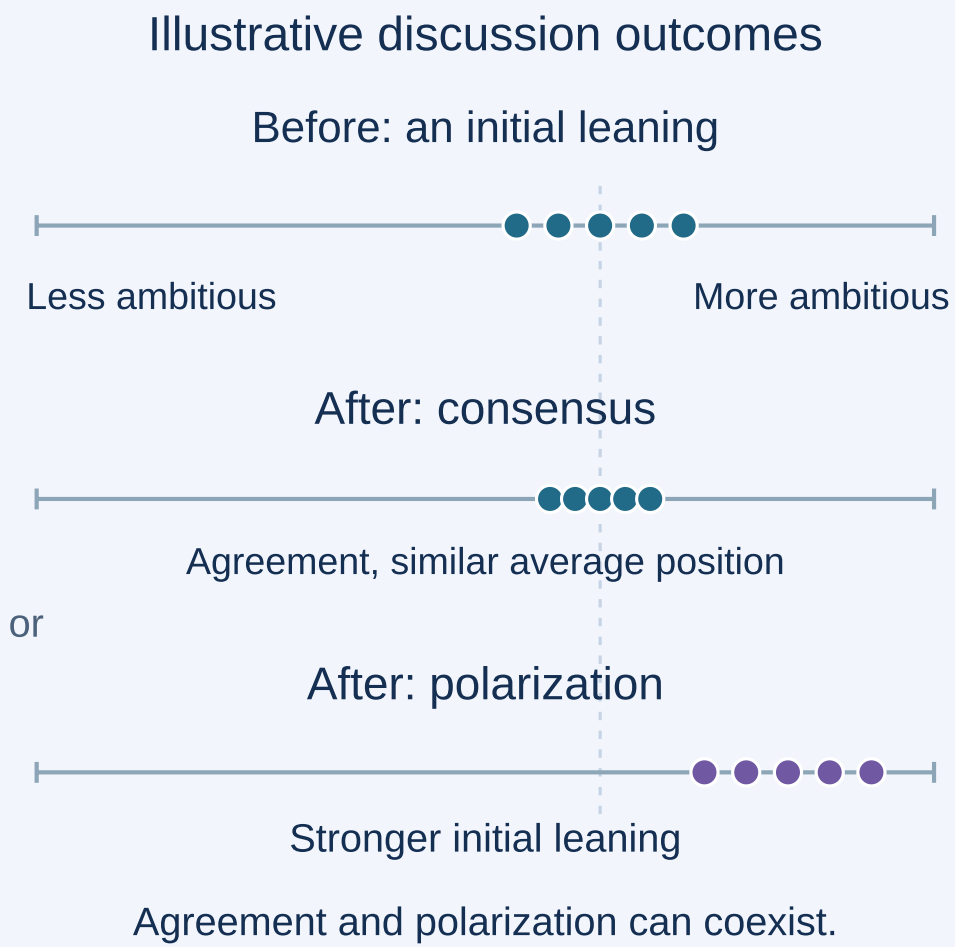
- **Social identity**: groups help define who we are.
- **In-group favoritism**: favoring “our” side.
- Shared goals can widen the circle.



Separate teams can coordinate around a shared goal.

Groups can amplify—or lose—effort.

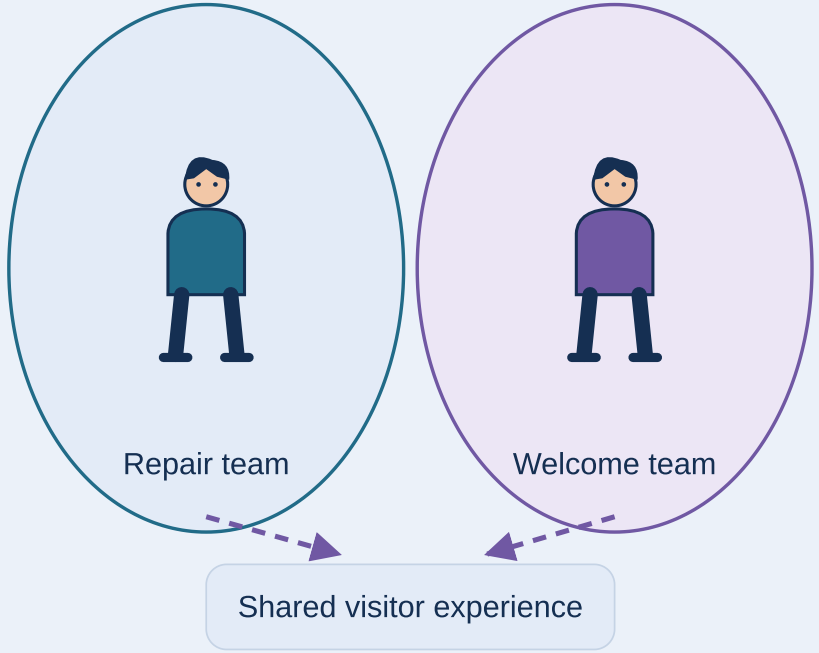
- **Group polarization**: discussion can intensify a group’s initial leaning.
- **Social loafing**: individual effort can fall in pooled work.
- **Coordination loss**: real effort is poorly combined.



Agreement can form with or without a more extreme leaning.

What can we really conclude?

Groupthink describes cases where pressure for agreement interferes with critical discussion. The label does not fully explain every poor group decision. Look for an observable process. Were doubts suppressed? Was the same information repeated while other evidence was missed? Were roles or incentives unclear? Different processes need different remedies. Independent estimates can broaden the evidence. Clear roles can improve coordination. Structured disagreement can make concerns easier to express.



Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

An event budget keeps escalating without checking demand. What helps?

A Ask members to show stronger enthusiasm.

B Gather independent estimates and contrary evidence.

C Open with the chair’s preferred budget.

Suggested answer: B. Independent estimates and contrary evidence give the group information beyond its existing enthusiasm.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> How does polarization differ from consensus?

> How can a willing group still perform poorly?

1. Consensus is agreement. Polarization is movement toward a more extreme position from an initial leaning.

2. A willing group can still lose output through poor sequencing, duplicated work, missing tools, or unclear roles.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Map a shared project: each task, its owner, what must happen before it can start, and when progress will be checked. Decide whether the main obstacle is effort, coordination, or decision quality before proposing a remedy.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 8 · Story

“Anyone can join.” The form says otherwise.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



The invisible doorway · c08s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

How should the team investigate unequal access?

A Ask whether organizers consider themselves fair.

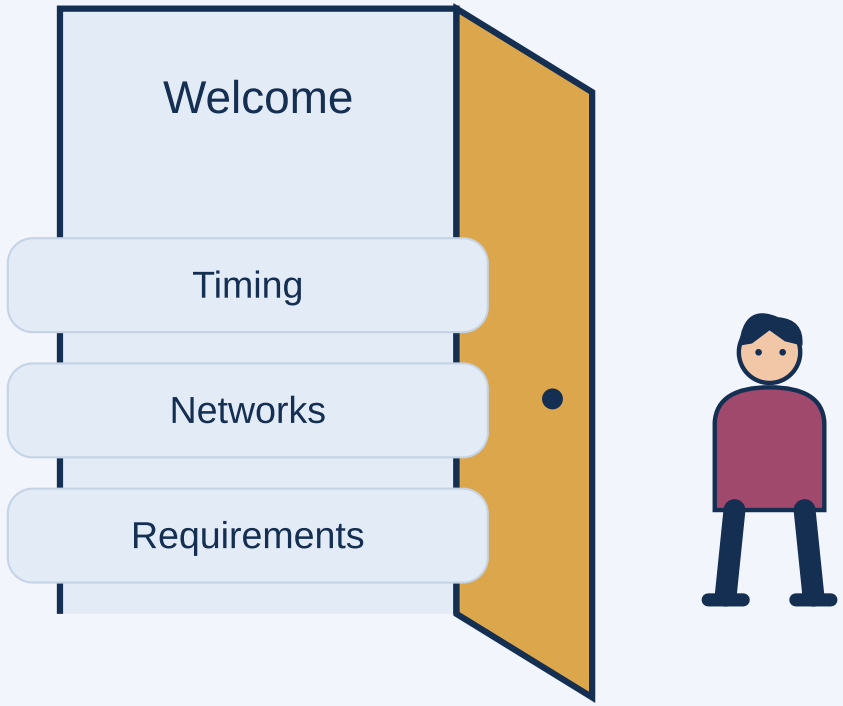
B Trace who can enter each stage and where people drop out.

C Add a fairness slogan to the poster.

Suggested answer: B. Tracing each stage can reveal access barriers that intentions and slogans miss.

Belief, feeling, and action are distinct.

- **Stereotype**: a generalized group belief.
- **Prejudice**: a group attitude, often involving dislike.
- **Discrimination**: unequal treatment based on group membership.

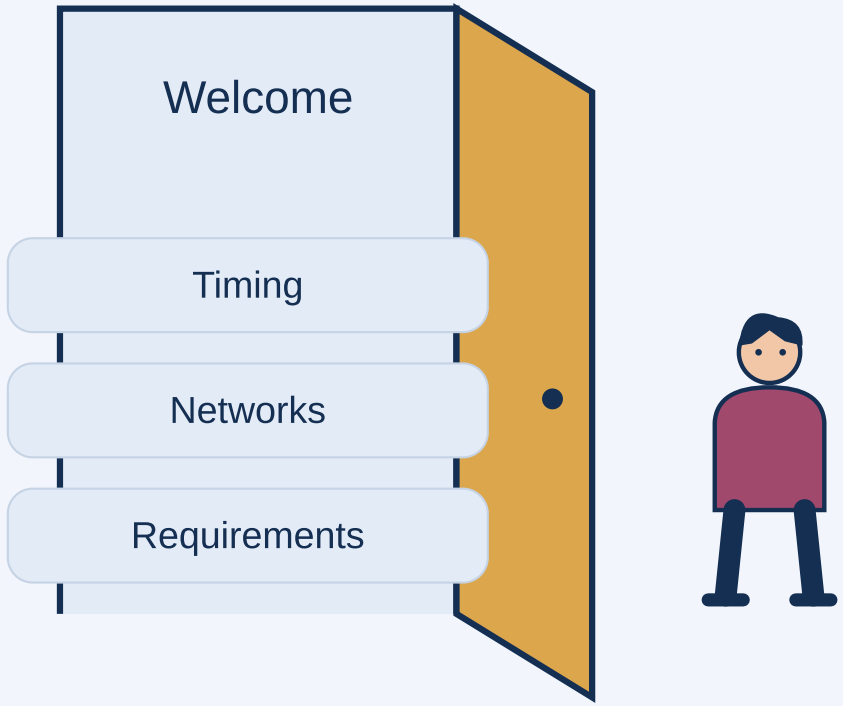


Good intentions do not remove every barrier.

Timing, networks, and requirements can restrict access.

Change the encounter and the structure.

- **Intergroup contact**: interaction between members of different groups.
- Support cooperation, shared goals, equal status, and backing from organizers.
- **Procedural change**: remove an unnecessary entry requirement.
- Evaluate whether people can actually participate.

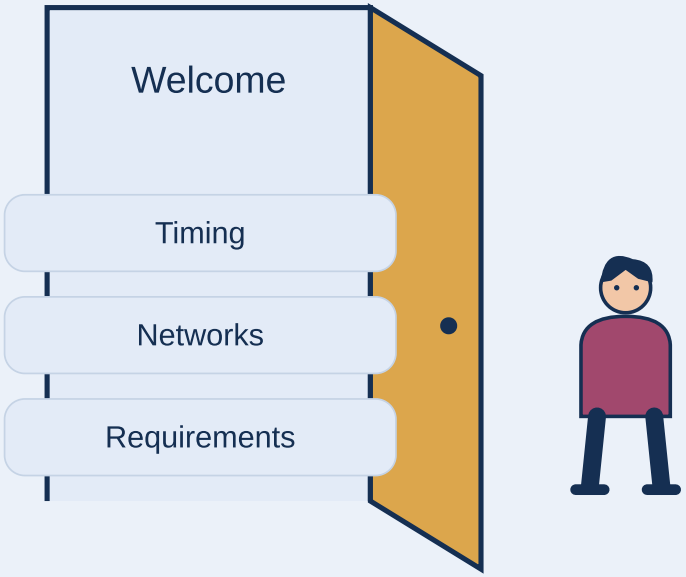


Good intentions do not remove every barrier.

Timing, networks, and requirements can restrict access.

What can we really conclude?

An explicit attitude is an evaluation someone reports directly. An implicit association is a link between ideas that may be measured indirectly, such as through the speed of responses in a sorting task. Discriminatory behavior concerns how people are actually treated. Those are different things to measure. An implicit-association score is not a complete diagnosis of character or a forecast of every action. A statement of fairness also cannot establish fair treatment. Evaluate changes using meaningful outcomes: who can apply, progress through recruitment, and participate afterward? Include follow-up and the experiences of people affected. Interpret small samples cautiously and protect privacy. Investigating unequal access does not justify collecting unnecessary personal information.



Good intentions do not remove every barrier.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Friend referrals become an open skills-based application. How can improvement be assessed?

A Check whether organizers feel more inclusive.

B Compare the friendliness of form wording.

C Track applications, progression, and participation using relevant criteria.

Suggested answer: C. Applications, progression, and participation can show where barriers remain. Interpret those outcomes with context and privacy safeguards.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Give an example of discrimination without an openly hostile statement.

> Why might a contact event leave unequal access unchanged?

1. An irrelevant requirement or restricted network can exclude a group without an openly hostile statement.

2. Contact can leave unequal access unchanged when decision power, incentives, status differences, or procedures remain the same.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Review a process you are authorized to examine. Identify an unnecessary barrier, propose a change, and select a fair outcome measure without collecting unnecessary personal data.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 9 · Story

Friendship begins with the quiet shift.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

A newcomer hopes to make friends. What is a respectful starting point?

A Offer a shared activity and notice reciprocal interest.

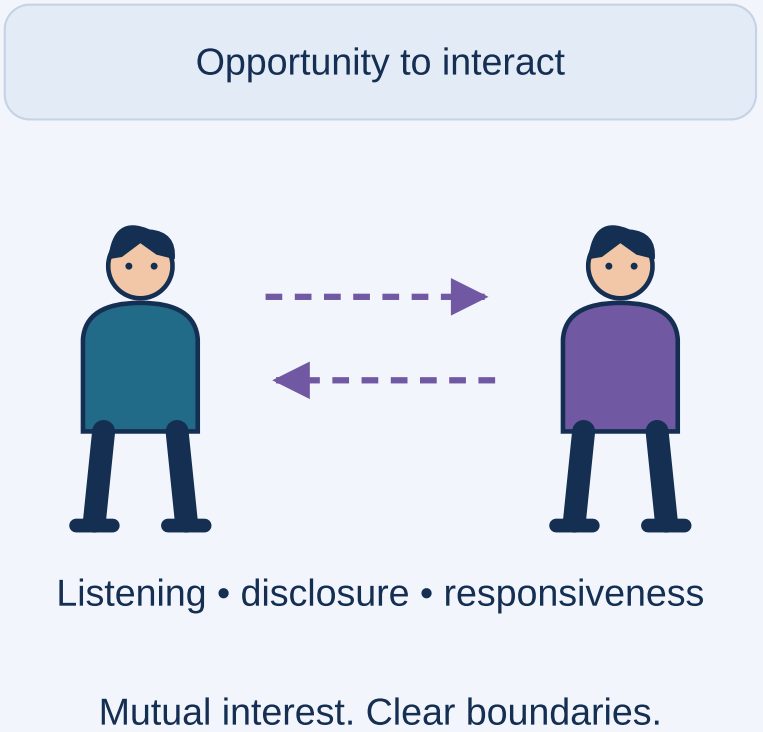
B Share increasingly private details until closeness develops.

C Keep arranging contact after invitations are declined.

Suggested answer: A. Offering a shared activity creates an opportunity to connect. Notice whether the other person also chooses to participate and show interest.

Opportunity shapes who becomes familiar.

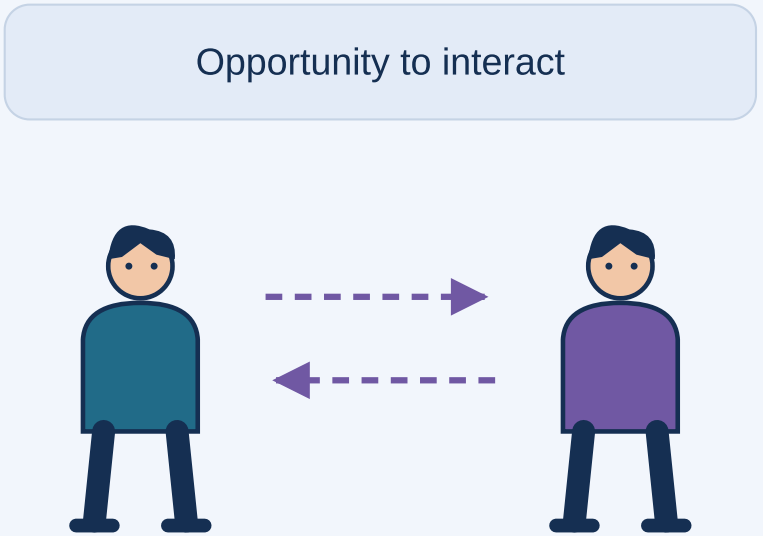
- Proximity creates opportunities to meet.
- **Mere exposure effect**: familiarity can increase liking in some conditions.
- Similarity can make interaction easier.



Connection depends on mutual responsiveness and boundaries.

Closeness is a reciprocal process.

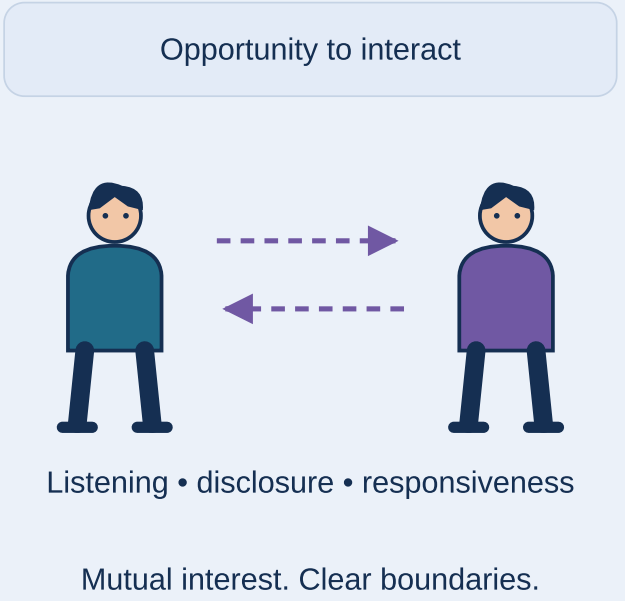
- **Disclosure**: sharing something personal.
- **Responsiveness**: helping someone feel understood.
- **Reciprocity**: mutual consideration over time.
- Attachment labels are not diagnoses; willingness and boundaries still matter.



Connection depends on mutual responsiveness and boundaries.

What can we really conclude?

Much relationship research examines associations or asks people to report their own experiences. Self-reports provide information about those experiences, but people may remember events differently or answer in ways they prefer others to see. Samples may also represent only particular cultures or relationship forms. Suppose similar partners report greater satisfaction. That association does not, by itself, establish that making two people more similar would improve their relationship. Other factors might contribute to both similarity and satisfaction. Distinguish an average association from advice for a particular pair. Ask about their experience directly. A conversation may reveal important details that a catchy compatibility rule overlooks.



Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Sam declines an invitation and needs time alone. What should Leo do?

A Diagnose an avoidant attachment style.

B Accept the boundary and leave future contact optional.

C Increase contact to use the familiarity effect.

Suggested answer: B. Accepting the invitation refusal respects Sam’s stated preference without inventing a diagnosis.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> How can proximity affect friendship?

> Why is disclosure alone insufficient?

1. Proximity changes opportunities to interact and discover shared interests.

2. Disclosure alone is insufficient because willingness, responsiveness, trust, context, and mutual boundaries also matter.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

In a willing everyday conversation, ask an open question and summarize what you heard before offering advice. Reflect on whether the person seemed heard and understood, and whether you gave them room to correct your summary.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 10 · Story

A crash. A full room. A moment of hesitation.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



Who will do something? · c10s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

Why could concerned bystanders hesitate?

A Concern disappears when groups become large.

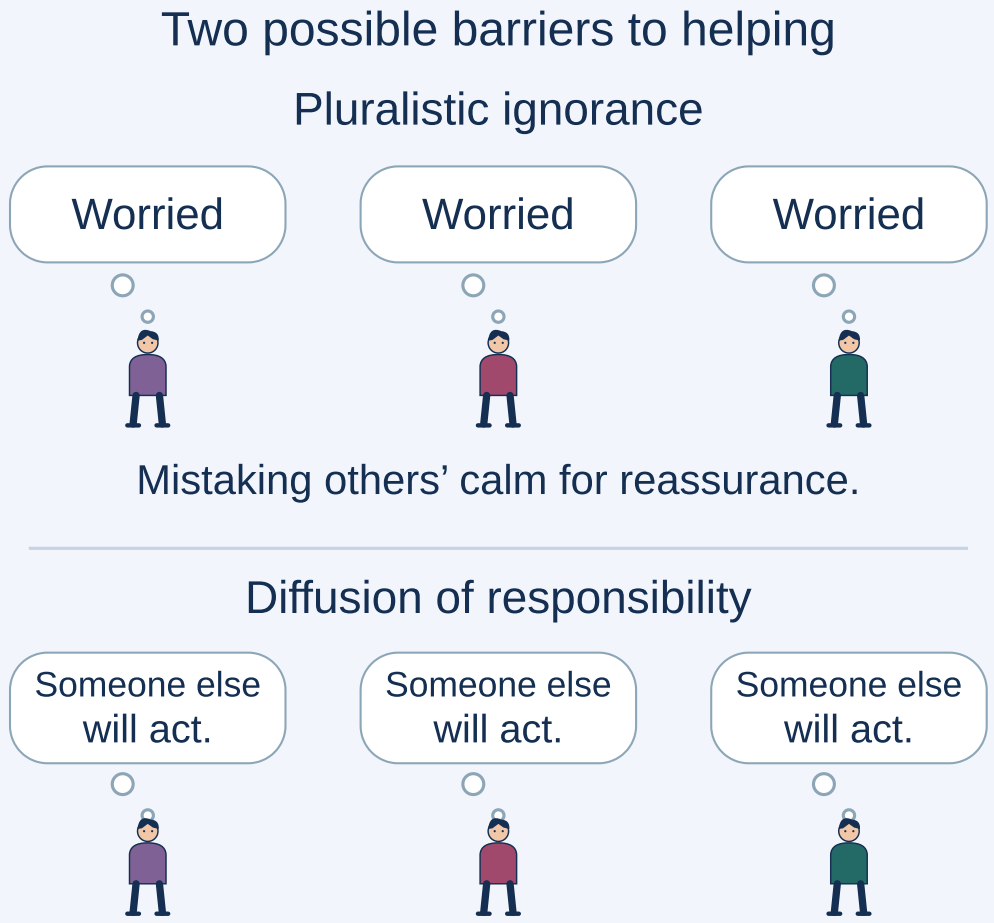
B People may be uncertain and assume someone else will act.

C Hesitation proves nobody cares.

Suggested answer: B. People may be unsure whether help is needed, or think someone else is responsible for acting.

Helping has several decision points.

- **Bystander effect**: others' presence can reduce an individual's chance of helping.
- **Diffusion of responsibility**: "Someone else will act."
- **Pluralistic ignorance**: "Everyone looks calm, so perhaps no help is needed."
- Help depends on context, skills, safety, and support.



Context, skills, and available support also shape helping.

Make constructive action easier.

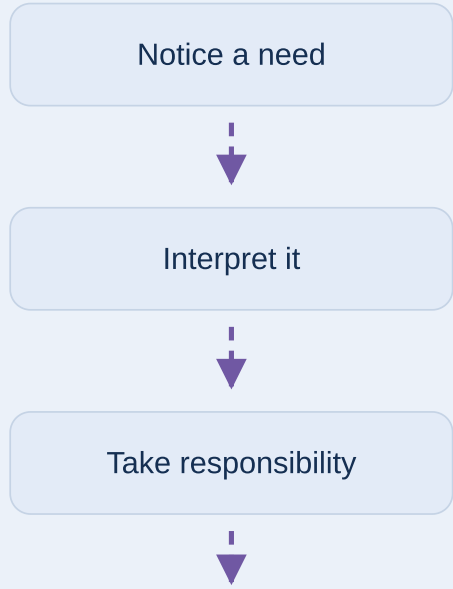
- **Aggression**: behavior intended to harm.
- **De-escalation**: lower threat and preserve safety.
- **Cooperation**: align goals, roles, and feedback.



Helping involves noticing, interpreting, responsibility, and safe action.

What can we really conclude?

Laboratory studies may measure aggression through controlled tasks, such as choosing an unpleasant noise for another participant. Such measures are imperfect indicators of serious violence outside the laboratory. Bystander findings also vary with danger, relationships, and available support. “Crowds don’t help” hides those differences and cannot explain every incident. For a real emergency, follow local guidance and your training. A social psychology explanation does not replace first-aid instruction. Evaluate practical changes by whether appropriate, safe help becomes more available. A team saying it cares does not establish that its response plan works.



Choose a safe action within your ability.

Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Which preparation makes future help more likely?

A Tell everyone to be more caring.

B Assume the most senior person handles all incidents.

C Agree on response roles, training, and a call-for-help route.

Suggested answer: C. Roles, training, and a call-for-help route address ability and responsibility as well as good intentions.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Distinguish diffusion of responsibility from pluralistic ignorance.

> Use two ideas from earlier chapters to improve an incident review.

1. Diffusion of responsibility concerns who should act. Pluralistic ignorance concerns how people interpret others' reactions.

2. For an incident review, separate observations from blame, compare possible causes, invite independent accounts, or assign clear roles. These draw on chapters one, two, five, and seven.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Design a helping plan for a low-risk shared task: signal, named role, safe action, and feedback. Explain how context, evidence, influence, and group structure shape your plan.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.